

years and you may make enough money to last a lifetime. Most young people keep working past age 35, 40, or 45 and pile up wealth. But if you're prepared to make it happen, the forty-year career can go the way of vacuum tubes, mono records, and domestic oil supplies.

Some say America is changing from a smokestack to a service economy. Others are less kind. They say America's economy is falling apart. Big labor has lost its ability to protect the rank and file. Japan and Korea are changing the way we think and work, and the British-style Fleet Street hype has taken over TV and most of the press. Huge numbers of college students struggle to read and write. They graduate without having learned to think or decide. Product quality is an impossible dream in many industries, and the focus on current earnings per share plagues even the most farsighted planners. All that's left, it seems, is to work hard and make money.

I believe most young managers respect the system. They know it's a long shot, but they still hope to wind up in power by the time they're 50. But today, unlike a few decades ago, one needs more than the right M.B.A. or the ability to put a smile on the boss's face. The surplus of baby boomers means that the system will be less and less able to make room for good people at upper levels. We need to find new opportunities for sharp, hardworking people who leave the corporate structure.

Up to now, those outlets have been second careers, the Peace Corps, turning a hobby into a business, and the like. Those outlets give you at least some money to live on. The route I describe in this book offers more freedom. The dramatic feature of my plan is that you live the rest of your life without earning another dime. You let your equity sweat for you. You can have the incredible luxury of looking at life as a brand new ball game, nearly without economic restraints, while you still have a keen mind and active spirit.

It sounds scary, and it is scary. But once you decide to get